

Polar Bears: Life in the Arctic

Polar bears are large bears adapted to the cold, remote Arctic. They are found across countries including Canada, Russia, and Norway.

Adaptation to a cold environment

Polar bears have thick fur, a layer of fat, large paws, and small ears. These features help them retain heat and move across ice and snow. Their fur is usually translucent, so the skin underneath appears dark.

Diet and hunting

Polar bears are predators whose main food is ringed seals and bearded seals. They hunt near breathing holes, where seals come up to breathe. When sea ice is unavailable, bears may eat eggs, vegetation, or carrion. Their diet is high in fat, which supplies energy in the Arctic winter.

Habitat and movement

Sea ice is the bear's most important habitat and hunting platform. They can travel long distances to follow sea ice and food sources. Female bears raise cubs in dens, often on land near the ice edge.

Conservation and the future

Climate change is warming the Arctic faster than many other regions.
As sea ice forms later and melts earlier, bears have less time to hunt.
Long periods without ice can cause bears to exhaust their energy stores.

Threats to polar bears

Oil and gas development, shipping, and tourism can affect coastal habitats.
Pollution and disturbance may also create additional risks for bears.
Slow environmental changes make it difficult for populations to adapt.

What people can do

Reducing greenhouse-gas emissions helps protect sea ice and food sources.
Communities can support responsible tourism and safe wildlife distances.
Researchers use satellite images and tracking data to study bear populations.
Protecting migration corridors and reducing human-wildlife conflict are important.

Conclusion

Polar bears are an important part of Arctic ecosystems.
Their future depends on preserving sea ice and reducing climate change.
Understanding this connection helps people make informed decisions.